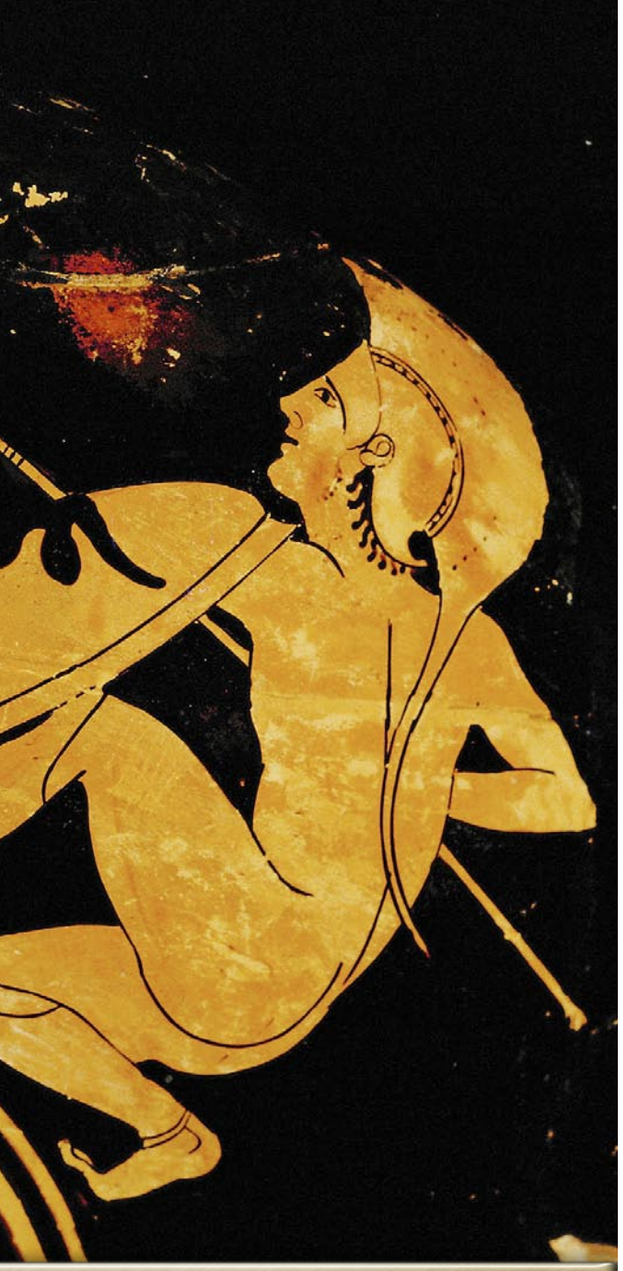
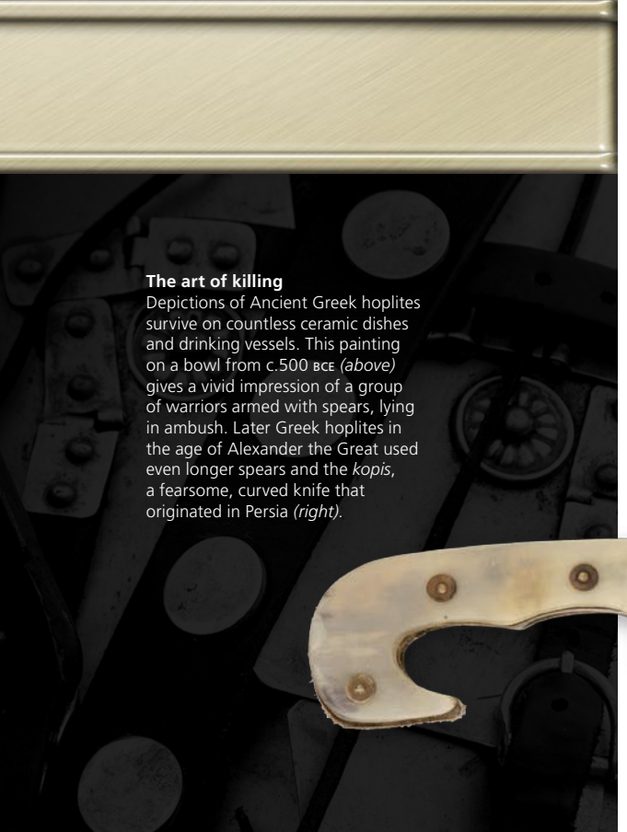


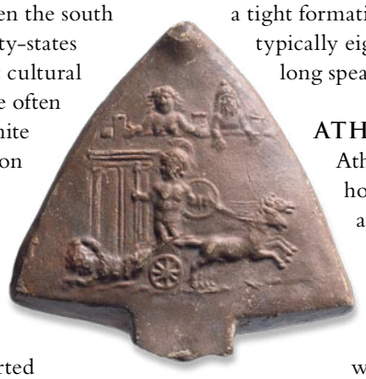
The art of killing
Depictions of Ancient Greek hoplites survive on countless ceramic dishes and drinking vessels. This painting on a bowl from c.500 BCE *(above)* gives a vivid impression of a group of warriors armed with spears, lying in ambush. Later Greek hoplites in the age of Alexander the Great used even longer spears and the *kopis*, a fearsome, curved knife that originated in Persia *(right)*.



THE KOPIS, A LONG SLASHING KNIFE

THE CITY-STATES OF ANCIENT GREECE invented a distinctive kind of armoured infantry force: the hoplites. These spear-armed citizen-soldiers proved their worth in the 5th century BCE, first in the repulse of Persian invaders and then in the Peloponnesian Wars that pitted Athens against Sparta. Widely recognized as the finest foot soldiers of their time, Greek hoplites later served in the all-conquering army of Alexander the Great and as mercenaries in the service of other powers, including the Egyptians and Persians.

The Ancient Greek world embraced not only mainland Greece, but extended along the coast of modern Turkey and across the Mediterranean to Sicily, southern Italy, and even the south of France. Though the many city-states and their colonies showed great cultural unity, politically they were more often than not divided. They could unite to counter the threat of a common enemy, as they had done against the Trojans in the legendary era of prehistory described in Homer's epic poem, the *Iliad*. This they did again, although not without disagreements and near-disasters, when they thwarted the invasion attempts of the Persian kings Darius and Xerxes in the early years of the 5th century BCE. But in the second half of the century rivalry between Athens and Sparta provoked the so-called Peloponnesian War (431–404 BCE). The alliances formed by the two main powers during this period involved almost all the Greek city-states and as a result their citizens had to be in a state of permanent readiness for war. The warriors who did the bulk of the fighting in the long bloody struggle that developed were the hoplites.



The Trojan War
This relief shows Achilles dragging the body of Hector around the walls of Troy.

WEAPONS AND TACTICS

Service as a hoplite was both a duty and a privilege of adult males enjoying full citizen status. The two most prominent city-state armies, those of Athens and of Sparta, were broadly similar in their equipment and tactics. The hoplite wore thick, heavy bronze armour consisting of a cuirass, greaves to protect his legs, and a helmet; he carried a large shield, a spear, and a short iron sword. He fought in a tight formation known as a phalanx, typically eight ranks deep, using the long spear as his primary weapon.

ATHENIAN HOPLITES

Athens and Sparta differed sharply, however, in their organization and training. In Athens hoplites were barely trained part-timers, expected to abandon their civilian occupation and present themselves for service whenever the state required. They had to buy their own equipment. A full panoply of armour was very expensive and almost certainly beyond the means of many Athenians, who will have presented themselves with only part of the standard kit. The wealthiest citizens, on the other hand, were decked out in the finest armour to proclaim their status. Those too poor to own any armour at all often ended up becoming oarsmen in the Athenian fleet. One man who served Athens in this way was the philosopher Socrates.

Although the traditional practice of foot-racing, wrestling, and other competitive sports provided the Athenians with a kind of physical conditioning, they seem to have had little or no formal military training or drill. But they were free men fighting for their city and their honour, and thus exhibited at times a high level of morale and commitment.